

The Great Awakening of QAnon's *Weltanschauung*: A Psychoanalytic Interpretation of Conspiracy Theory in an Age of 'Post-truth'



The 'QAnon Shaman' amidst other protestors in Phoenix, Arizona, in response to unverified claims that Donald Trump was cheated out of votes in the US election (OLIVIER TOURON/AFP via Getty Images, 5th Nov 2020). Available at: <https://www.gettyimages.co.uk/detail/news-photo/man-holds-a-sign-reading-q-sent-me-as-supporters-of-us-news-photo/1229483334?adppopup=true>

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Key Words: QAnon, Lacan, Jouissance, Hysteric, Discourse, Barthes,
Žižek, Psychoanalysis, Paranoia

(Word Count: 7,636)

Introduction

To talk of ‘post-truth’ is to highlight the recent political and psychic phenomena in our late modern era; it epitomizes the disintegration of traditional media models and the increased usage of digitalised social media as a source of news which, in turn, has allowed cult-like conspiracy theory groups such as QAnon to be pulled into the limelight. QAnon has become mainstream: ‘Q’ and the consequential online related content has become a news source for thousands – potentially millions – of people across the United States.¹ In September 2020, a study had shown that almost half of Americans had heard of the group, and of those who had heard of it, a fifth had a positive opinion on the movement.² What is startling is the fact that in our current climate, ever more people are willing to turn to conspiracy theories in order to get closer to the ‘truth’. The main premise of the QAnon conspiracy theory is that the world is run by a cabal of paedophilic, Satan-worshipping elites who are known as the ‘deep state’. Trump was envisioned as the saviour; the narrative is framed as a classic battle between good and evil. The movement itself began in 2017 when an anonymous user named ‘Q’ started posting on the message board ‘4Chan’, offering users cryptic posts detailing supposed secret knowledge of the ‘deep state’. Even though Donald Trump is no longer president, the group still prevails, and it is important to point out that the movement has had real-world implications: the virtual world has bled into real violence.³

After the relatively recent events involving the likes of Jeffrey Epstein and Jimmy Saville in addition to the expansion of the internet - a powerful social technology - it is not hard to imagine how QAnon has grown to the size it has. While the majority of members’ beliefs

¹ Mallory Newall, ‘More than 1 in 3 Americans believe a ‘deep state’ is working to undermine Trump’, *Ipsos*, (December 2020), <https://www.ipsos.com/en-us/news-polls/npr-misinformation-123020>.

² Amy Mitchell, Mark Jurkowitz, J. Baxter Oliphant and Elisa Shearer, ‘Political Divides, Conspiracy Theories and Divergent News Sources Heading Into 2020 Election’, *Pew Research Centre*, (September 2020), pp. 36-37.

³ Mack Lamoureux, ‘Conspiracy Theorist Who Stormed Trudeau’s Property Sentenced to Six Years’, *Vice*, (March, 2021), <https://www.vice.com/en/article/m7aydq/corey-hurren-conspiracy-theorist-who-stormed-justin-trudeaus-property-sentenced-to-six-years>.

display alt-right undertones, it is also worth mentioning that there are those who use the posts as a form of play, treating the ‘Q drops’ only as an ARG (alternate reality game) without fully believing in the word of ‘Q’. An ARG is an “interactive networked narrative that uses the real world as a platform and employs transmedia storytelling to deliver a story that may be altered by player’s ideas and actions.”⁴ For those who take it seriously, the red pill/blue pill scene in *The Matrix* perfectly symbolises the choice each of us have to make: whether to join the ranks and prepare ourselves for ‘The Great Awakening’ or to remain asleep, living a life ignorant to the fact that there is a ‘deep state’ controlling the political realm.⁵ ‘The Great Awakening’ refers to us opening our eyes to the enormous web of conspiracy theory that evolved from the main premise, all existing as an inter-related set of conspiratorial beliefs.

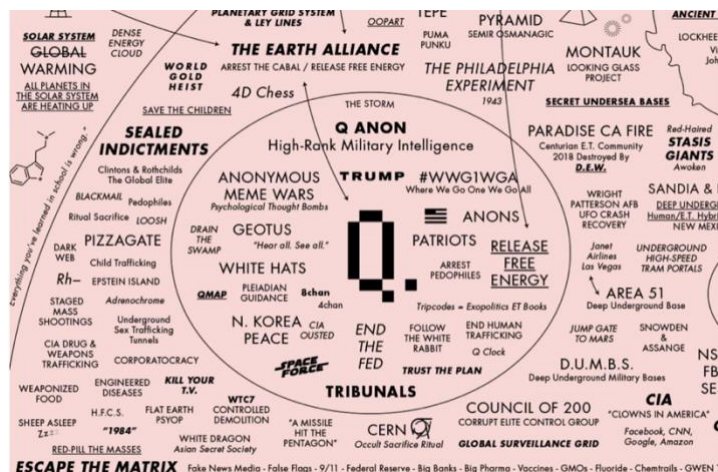


Figure 1: ‘The Great Awakening’ map. QAnon is only one section of the conspiracy theory web known as ‘The Great Awakening’. Available at: greatawakeningmap.co

Through an interpretation of Barthes’s essays ‘From Work to Text’ and ‘The Death of the Author’, it will become evident that QAnon’s web of conspiracy theory (partly shown in Figure 1) is the direct result of ‘Q drops’ being left up to the reader to create signification; it is

⁴ Julianne Tippet, ‘Will QAnon ever go away?’, in *The Tartan*, (February 2021), <https://thetartan.org/2021/3/1/forum/qanon>.

⁵ WWG1WGA, *QAnon: An Invitation to The Great Awakening*, (Dallas: Relentlessly Creative Books, 2019), p. 6.

left up to the reader to form an anarchic constellation out of the galaxy of signifiers which, in turn, allows any conspiracy theory to fit into QAnon's *Weltanschauung* (worldview). I will also highlight the psychoanalytic influences in Barthes's essays for the dominant focus of this project is to understand and interpret QAnon through a psychoanalytic lens. This will be beneficial because Lacanian psychoanalysis does not aim at being a "metalanguage" yet "allows us to understand the functioning of different discourses in a unique way."⁶

Barthes and Lacan will be used as means to unveil how framing the 'Q' posts as a 'Text' allows us to see how 'Q drops' are bound to *jouissance*. Not only that, what will be demonstrated is how our current information environment – aided by the birth of the internet – has allowed such a group to grow exponentially, and through Lacanian psychoanalysis, it will be made apparent that such expansion is related to what Žižek defines as the "demise of symbolic efficiency". Even though there is a combination of perversion, psychosis and neurosis within QAnon, what I aim to reveal is how the neurotic discourse of the hysteric has led to the collapse of master discourses, undermining the authority of both master and knowledge. This again correlates itself with the demise of symbolic efficiency, the disintegration of the already non-existent big Other, and such a demise has also led to a paranoid fantasy of a 'deep state' within their discourse.

The Birth of the Internet and the Death of the Author

The internet has endowed us with the ability to expand above and beyond our horizons, where we can share our views on a variety of topics; we are able to assert our personal, political and religious opinions onto a virtual space in an instant. Traditional forms of preaching tactics have almost entirely evaporated: there is no longer a need to hand out flyers or stand in the middle

⁶ Bruce Fink, *The Lacanian Subject: Between Language and Jouissance*, (New Jersey: Princeton University Press, 1995), p. 129.

of a town square to express your own worldview.⁷ This means that it is much easier to spread controversial viewpoints on particular matters, and as Kathleen Stewart points out: “The Internet was made for conspiracy theory: it is a conspiracy theory: one thing leads to another, always another link leading you deeper into no thing and no place.”⁸ The birth of the internet has created an era of information overload: we are unable to form a clear and complete picture of events due to the overwhelming volume of competing narratives that exist on the internet. This may also be depicted as the condition caused by the disintegration of our belief in the promise of the Enlightenment project.⁹ Jodi Dean eloquently describes this predicament, making it apparent that “bringing every relevant and available fact into the conversation, as Hebermasians like to say, may well entangle us in a clouded, occluded nightmare of obfuscation.”¹⁰ We live in an epoch that denotes a collapse of faith in “grand narratives” and the truths to which they recourse, where we have to play the role of arbiter between a sheer array of different and competing accounts. This could be said to be the fate of signification in our postmodern, digital age.

This collapse of ‘meta-narratives’ which has left us to pick and choose from competing and multiplying narratives aligns itself with what Žižek defines as the “demise of symbolic efficiency.”¹¹ The internet has endowed us with the ideas associated with postmodernity, where we see the unstable nature of signification and the absence of universal and knowable truths being brought into our everyday lives. We no longer take the mainstream media representations to be the absolute truth as there are always competing narratives that exist online. Our current online information environment that was caused by this crisis of representation is thus closely

⁷ Adam Possamai, ‘Yoda Goes to Glastonbury: An Introduction to Hyper-real Religions’ in *Handbook of Hyper-real Religions*, ed. by Adam Possamai, (Boston: Brill, 2012), p. 2.

⁸ Kathleen Stewart, ‘Conspiracy Theory’s Worlds’, in *Paranoia Within Reason*, (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1999), p. 18.

⁹ Mark Andrejevic, ‘Theory Glut: From Critique to Conspiracy’, in *Infoglut: How Too Much Information Is Changing the Way We Think and Know*, (New York: Routledge, 2013), p. 221.

¹⁰ Jodi Dean, ‘Theorizing Conspiracy Theory’, in *Theory & Event*, vol. 4, no. 3, (2000), p. 1.

¹¹ Slavoj Žižek, *The Ticklish Subject: The Absent Centre of Political Ontology*, (London: Verso, 1999), p. 322. The phrase “demise of symbolic efficiency” will be explored further in the following chapters.

linked to the logic of conspiracy theory. In our current climate in which we experience an overload of information on virtually anything you could imagine, we become overwhelmed, where we deduce that our knowledge is perpetually incomplete, believing that there is always more to the story. Once again, Dean makes it apparent that “these two ideas, that things are not as they seem and everything is connected, are primary components of how we think about and experience the information age. They are also the guiding impulses of conspiracy theory.”¹² With the rise of the internet in line with the ‘end of great narratives’, it was only a matter of time for a phenomenon like QAnon to occur. People want to have a coherent picture of what is going on around them, even if this does lead to the type of thinking we see in QAnon - there exists a strong distrust of the dominant news sources which is in line with the crisis of representation that is associated with the internet and postmodernity.

Yet another extension of the internet consists of the potential to hide behind our screens; we can remain anonymous in an ever more public, interconnected reality. For the anonymous user named ‘Q’, the letter is used to refer to their high-level government official status, as someone who has access to secret government documents as a result of their Q clearance. In reality, however, it could be anyone hiding behind this pseudonym. Furthermore, the slogan “Where We Go One, We Go All” (WWG1WGA) is popular among members and it is evident that the phrase is used as a pseudonym in *QAnon: An Invitation to The Great Awakening*.¹³ This book is an example of a manifesto written by 12 anonymous QAnon followers which surprisingly accumulated a substantial amount of traction in 2019, reaching ninth on ‘Hot New Releases’ in the politics section of US Amazon before it was taken down.¹⁴ In a similar fashion

¹² Jodi Dean, ‘Theorizing Conspiracy Theory’, op. cit., p. 2.

¹³ WWG1WGA, *QAnon: An Invitation to The Great Awakening*, op. cit.

¹⁴ Ben Collins, ‘On Amazon, a QAnon conspiracy book climbs the charts – with an algorithmic push’, *NBC News*, (March 2019), <https://www.nbcnews.com/tech/tech-news/amazon-qanon-conspiracy-book-climbs-charts-algorithmic-push-n979181>.

to ‘Q’, the pseudonym ‘WWG1WGA’ was used as a mask, and such a technique portrays the implications of what Barthes defines as the “death of the author”.¹⁵

A screenshot of a post from the 4chan messaging board. The post header shows the user 'Q !ITPb.qbhqo' with ID 'rHXVKCrC' and a timestamp of 'Tue 21 Nov 2017 18:43:15'. Below the header is a long list of quoted users, each preceded by '>>'. The main body of the post contains a series of lines: 'Expand your thinking.', 'Captain Mike Green.', '_Conf_D-TT_^_v891_0600_yes', '_green1_0600', 'Bunker Apple Yellow Sky [... + 1]', 'Yes.', 'Who countered?', 'Do you believe in coincidences?', 'Learn how to read the map.', and finally 'Q'.

Figure 2: A ‘Q drop’ highlighting the use of the letter ‘Q’ as a pseudonym by the author of the post. Posted on the messaging board 4Chan. Available at: https://anonfile.com/W7x2m3d4b1/Q_Map_12_14_2017v2.pdf

The rhetorical effect of using the letter ‘Q’ comes down to what it represents (Q clearance) but as mentioned prior, no one truly knows who this anonymous user is or what his real intentions are. This can be seen in Figure 2, where the author signs off the post with the letter ‘Q’. We are also given what the QAnon community like to call ‘crumbs’ which are little telegraphic clues that the reader must decode. ‘Q’ states “Bunker Apple Yellow Sky” and asks us to “Learn how to read the map” which are both good examples of ‘crumbs’ that are left for the audience (‘bakers’) to interpret. It seems as though there is a lot more emphasis placed on the job of the QAnon members than on the author himself/herself. Roland Barthes rests much more importance on the reader, and in the final sentence of ‘The Death of the Author’, he states

¹⁵ Roland Barthes, ‘The Death of the Author’, *Image-Music-Text*, trans. Stephen Heath, (London: Fontana Press, 1977), pp. 142-149.

this in a rather transparent manner: “The birth of the reader must be at the cost of the death of the Author.”¹⁶ The reader has much more importance in terms of determining meaning from a given text - it is the language rather than the author that speaks.¹⁷ It is apparent that within the texts by ‘Q’ and the QAnon manifesto, we are presented only with language that acts and “performs”, existing in the movement of a discourse, separated from the author themselves.¹⁸

We have no way of knowing the background of these authors which highlights the fact that they do not possess sovereignty over the words, for they belong to the reader, who interprets what is written. The ambiguity of Q’s true identity which probe the implications of the “death of the author” open up a space where followers have an important role in extracting significance; there is an eruption of differing interpretations of what each text actually portrays. It is up to the reader to decipher the ‘crumbs’ left behind from each post and connect the dots to form a coherent whole, even if this means that each reader comes to a different judgement on what this whole is. Thus, this gives rise to an entire web of conspiracy theories that extend out from these posts, for each member interprets them differently. If Q’s actual identity had ever been revealed, this would have established a limit as we could not freely interpret beyond the author’s signification; his posts would have been furnished with a final signified, closing the writing off for good.

This theme is explored further in Barthes’s essay ‘From Work to Text’,¹⁹ where it becomes apparent that Q’s posts should be framed as a “Text” rather than a piece of “work”. It is a Text in the sense that Q drops are partaking in a dialogue with the reader, and it is like an event, where the meaning of the posts are constantly evolving, ‘becoming’. In contrast to this, work is seen as an organic whole, already complete, and Barthes states that “the work is a

¹⁶ Ibid., p. 148.

¹⁷ Ibid., p. 143.

¹⁸ Ibid.

¹⁹ Roland Barthes, ‘From Work to Text’, *Image-Music-Text*, trans. Stephen Heath, (London: Fontana Press, 1977), pp. 155-164.

fragment of substance, occupying a part of the space of books (in a library for example), the Text is a methodological field.”²⁰ To further emphasise the dichotomy between “work” and “Text”, the difference is somewhat similar to Lacan’s differentiation between ‘reality’ and ‘the Real.’ In *Seminar XI*, ‘the real’ is described as “the impossible” as we are unable to imagine it, and it is also impossible in the sense that it completely resists symbolisation.²¹ Thus, we cannot attain and possess it like we can with a piece of work, and the Real’s refusal in being symbolised essentially demonstrates its traumatic quality. Reality, on the other hand, is the “grimace of the real”²² and stands for our subjective representations which are created by the imaginary and the symbolic (or what Freud termed as our ‘psychical reality’).²³ Therefore, ‘reality’ is similar to work in terms of how it can be displayed and grasped, while ‘the Real’ is like the Text as both can only be demonstrated.



Figure 3: A ‘Q’ post that was dropped on the messaging board ‘4Chan’, where Q leaves a series of “crumbs” for followers to decode (Nov 2020). Available at: https://anonfile.com/W7x2m3d4b1/Q_Map_12_14_2017v2.pdf

²⁰ Ibid., pp. 156-7.

²¹ Jacques Lacan, *Seminar Book XI: The Four Fundamental Concepts of Psychoanalysis*, trans. Alan Sheridan, (London: Hogarth Press and the Institute of Psychoanalysis, 1977), p. 167.

²² Jacques Lacan, *Television: A Challenge to the Psychoanalytic Establishment*, ed. Joan Copjec, trans. Denis Hollier, Rosalind Krauss and Annette Michelson, (New York: Norton, 1990), p. 17.

²³ Dylan Evens, *An Introductory Dictionary to Lacanian Psychoanalysis*, (London: Routledge, 1996), p. 166.

What is also made evident in ‘From Work to Text’ is that the Text’s meaning is disseminated, essentially plural and highly intertextual, whereas the piece of work possesses a singular fixed meaning, presenting itself as a finished object that was achieved by the brilliance of the author.²⁴ Figure 3 makes it apparent that those who follow ‘Q’ search the crumbs for little signs and clues that point towards hidden ‘knowledge’ found in between the lines in an almost game-like manner. ‘Q’ demands us to question and interpret intertextually. ‘Q’ asks the question “Why was the article published today?” to point the audience in a certain interpretive direction but when we are urged to “read between the lines”, this is more obscure and so burdens us with a more active interpretation. It is the reader’s job to supply the appropriate connections between each crumb; they are given the primary position of creating a quasi-coherent picture linguistically. For those treating the posts either as a source of truth or as an ARG alone, the game is influenced by the player’s ideas and actions. Accordingly, deciphering a Text is more like engaging in play than it is like partaking in a scientific investigation. The Text “practices the deferment of the signified” and so withstands a fixed meaning that specialists can be united on.²⁵

Reading and deciphering the Q drops as a Text means that the posts are bound to the term *jouissance*,²⁶ for the text of *jouissance* is a text which “imposes a state of loss, the text that discomforts (perhaps to the point of certain boredom), unsettles the reader’s historical, cultural, psychological assumptions, the consistency of his tastes, values, memories, brings to a crisis his relation to language.”²⁷ They shake up the reader’s sense of self and their identities are placed into question, and Q drops framed in this manner highlight the fact that the audience are covered in abrasions, cracks and unfillable holes in the Lacanian sense. *Jouissance* is a term often deployed by Lacan, treating it as a fleeting veil that hides the subject’s fundamental lack

²⁴ Barthes, ‘From Work to Text’, op. cit., pp. 159-160.

²⁵ Ibid., p. 158.

²⁶ Ibid., p. 164.

²⁷ Roland Barthes, *The Pleasure of the Text*, trans. Richard Miller, (New York: Hill and Wang, 1975), p. 14.

from which our desire takes root.²⁸ In a sense, *jouissance* carries the subject towards “the impossible” real, and it is a sensation that is linked to the ‘death-drive’ which exists beyond the pleasure principle (the pleasure principle being what Freud defines as our physical and mental mechanisms that attempt to reduce pain and maximise pleasure).²⁹

We want the satisfaction of going beyond the mere pleasure we obtain from desire. Pleasure is never quite enough to fully satisfy us, and we assume that there is more to be had, that we are missing out on something, and this thing that would fulfil us beyond pleasure is *jouissance*. However, we experience the sensation of *jouissance* through its lack and insufficiency; we are unsure what it is but we presume it exists as we are persistently dissatisfied.³⁰ Even though the translation of *jouissance* is normally equated to ‘enjoyment’, it is more accurate to state that it is a fusion of both pleasure and pain, or, more precisely, the pleasure we experience in pain.³¹ Hence, Q posts are bound to *jouissance* as QAnon followers experience a “state of loss”, a lack, causing members to question the assumptions they have on the world. It will become apparent later on that many of the QAnon members reside in the discourse of the hysteric, where we see the social phenomenon of constant questioning take place. QAnon seek more than the dissatisfaction of existence and as Bruce Fink suggests, “we think that there must be something better, we say that there must be something better, we believe that there must be something better.”³² *Jouissance*’s nothingness is turned into something with consistency; QAnon strive to fill up this lack to cure their discontent and yet they do not know what it is. This “state of loss” makes them question and doubt the master signifiers at play. Therefore, framing the message drops as a Text allows us to see how

²⁸ Lionel Bailey, *Lacan: A Beginner’s Guide*, (Oxford: Oneworld, 2009), p. 229.

²⁹ Sean Homer, *Jacques Lacan*, (London: Routledge, 2005), p. 89.

³⁰ *Ibid.*, p. 90.

³¹ *Ibid.*, p. 89.

³² Bruce Fink, ‘Knowledge and *Jouissance*’ in S. Bernard and B. Fink’s *Reading Seminar XX: Lacan’s Major Work on Love, Knowledge and Feminine Sexuality*, (New York: SUNY Press, 2002), p. 35.

jouissance is bound up to it, and it will become apparent how such a Text prohibits the readers to be more open minded to conspiratorial thinking.

While Text is bound to jouissance, “work” is only bound to the pleasure we get from it as an object of consumption. Q drops as a Text are “decanted” from its consumption and are intertwined with the free play of collaborative reading, narrowing the gap between ‘Q’ and his followers.³³ The overarching idea of Barthes’s essays is that once a text reaches its audience, the author of said text is no longer the adjudicator of its meaning. There can be no final word, no final interpretation of the text. There is an overwhelming volume of competing and multiplying narratives that can be found on the internet, but the posts produced by ‘Q’ allow the reader to create their own coherent yet incomplete account out of what is going on in the world. Even though each of the ‘crumbs’ stood alone are incoherent, the totality of QAnon’s theory is created by the individual’s re-reading of previously released clues and decoding the connection between them and each day’s new ‘crumb’; the theory itself is in a process of constant flux and yet it lays down a continually more complex vision of contemporary world politics. Our current online information environment holds the perfect conditions for QAnon to blossom: the environment itself is a galaxy of signifiers that we – as users of the internet – freely play around in, open to an anarchic constellation as a means to make a coherent whole.

QAnon: The Ultimate Hysteric Discourse?

Within QAnon discourse, it is important to emphasise that there exists a combination of perversion, psychosis and neurosis. In Lacanian discourse analysis, the four discourses of the neurotic represent how communication always fails, but it is this failure that pushes us to keep talking. It is impossible to put the repressed truth that drives the subject into words as

³³ Barthes, ‘From Work to Text’, op. cit., p. 162.

communication creates an excess remainder of the Real that cannot be verbalised. This element is what Lacan calls “the half-speaking of the truth”, and it is precisely this that puts us in a continual compulsion to repeat, to endlessly attempt to verbalise the non-verbal.³⁴ In addition to this, it is therefore important to emphasise that the four social links – which includes the discourse of the hysteric – are offered by Lacan as analytical assumptions, not as means of pathologisation.³⁵ For those lying in the hysteric discourse, which is one of the four social bonds of the neurotic, the main problem for them is that those who incarnate authority never succeed - they are never fully up to it - thus causing hysterical dissatisfaction and ever shifting desire.³⁶ Those residing in this discourse desire to know the truth, they persistently ask the master “Am I what you say I am? What are you saying and why are you saying that?”³⁷ However, there is never an answer that is deemed satisfactory; there is always constant doubt being cast over the hegemonic master signifier of the master or university discourse. The master is never quite master enough.³⁸

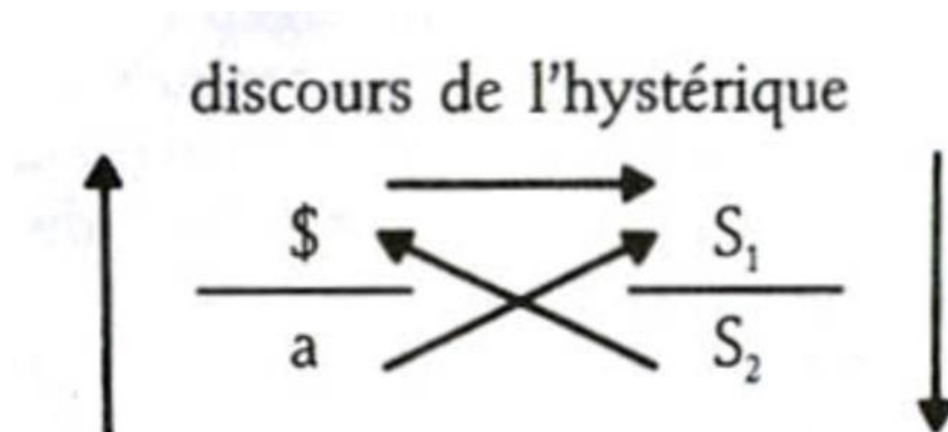


Figure 4: The Discourse of the Hysteric. Available at: <https://nosubject.com/Discourse>

³⁴ Paul Verhaeghe, *Does the Woman Exist? From Freud's Hysteric to Lacan's Feminine*, trans. Marc du Ry, (New York: Other Press, 1997), p. 102.

³⁵ Jodi Dean, *Democracy and Other Neoliberal Fantasies: Communicative Capitalism & Left Politics*, (Durham: Duke University Press, 2009), p. 149.

³⁶ Paul Verhaeghe, 'The Tactics of the Master: Paranoia versus Hysteria', *Journal of the Centre for Freudian Analysis and Research*, 8 & 9, (1997), pp. 67.

³⁷ Ibid.

³⁸ Alenka Zupančič, 'When Surplus Enjoyment Meets Surplus Value' in *Jacques Lacan and the Other Side of Psychoanalysis*, Ed. J. Clemens and R. Grigg, (Durham and London: Duke University Press, 2006), p. 165.

In order to decipher how the hysteric social bond functions in QAnon discourse, the general positions and elements in the matheme (as displayed in Figure 4) must be made apparent. In every one of the four neurotic social bonds (master, university, analyst and the hysteric), we witness the fact that the conscious *agent* is driven by an unconscious *truth* who, in turn, attempts to speak to an *Other*. This results in the creation of a *product* as a consequence of this exchange. In the discourse of the hysteric, the *agent* of this social link is the alienated barred subject (\$) who is split between the imaginary and the symbolic – the conscious and unconscious – as a result of symbolic castration.³⁹ Castration produced by the symbolic order (Law, language, culture) is caused by the split subject's relationship to the art of speech and language: language can never fully characterise the subject as it is impossible to contain everything in the form of a signifier. For the hysteric, the belief that there are humans who are not symbolically castrated prevails, seeing them as subjects “whose *jouissance* is not partially evacuated from their bodies by their accession to language.”⁴⁰ The barred subject (\$) demands the Other - who is always considered the master to the hysteric - to provide the master signifier (S₁) that demonstrates their transcendence of the castration produced by the symbolic order, believing that this will produce totalising knowledge (S₂) that will apprehend the truth of objet petit a (*a*).

Here arises the impossibility: the subject cannot get to the truth of object *a*, for the Other is also castrated by language and is subject to the Law, thus never being able to produce an answer that fully characterises the subject's repressed truth. There is impotence between the knowledge created by the master and the agent's truth (*a* // S₂) and so the subject remains stuck with this impossibility.⁴¹ Objet petit *a* is a rather obscure term which encapsulates the lost

³⁹ Jacques Lacan, *The Other Side of Psychoanalysis: The Seminar of Jacques Lacan Book XVII*, trans. Russell Grigg, (New York and London: W. W. Norton and Company, 2007), p. 97.

⁴⁰ Mark Bracher, *Lacanian Theory of Discourse: Subject, Structure and Society*, Ed. Bracher et al., (New York and London: New York University Press, 1994), p. 6.

⁴¹ Verhaeghe, *Does the Woman Exist? From Freud's Hysteric to Lacan's Feminine*, op. cit., p. 110.

object; it represents the existence of an excess remainder of the Real that is unaccounted for by the symbolic. Therefore, object *a* is an object of lack, consisting of nothing. However, such an object is the object-cause of desire since it “represents the final term for desire itself; as it lies beyond the realm of the signifier and thus beyond the pleasure principle, it is irrevocably lost. In that sense it constitutes the motor which keeps us going forever.”⁴² As a result of objet petit *a*, the subject can never be represented fully in the form of a signifier.

Being introduced into the world of language hysterises the subject, castrating them, creating a subject who always falls short in relation to what they are trying to say. They can therefore never be encapsulated by a signifier, meaning that they cannot be reduced to the meanings and signifiers they construct themselves. This failure conveys the fact that both the master and knowledge cannot imprison the split subject in their network - they are defiant to being detained - compromising the authority of both master and knowledge.⁴³ Vanheule summarises this predicament rather well:

Central to the discourse of hysteric is the active formulation of complaints (\$) and the search for an other who is presumed to have an answer (S₁) for what bothers the subject. This discourse represses the truth that all desires rest on a lack that cannot be alleviated (*a*), and typically results in the production of narratives (S₂) that don't solve the fundamental lack (*a*), but actually engender further irritation (\$).⁴⁴

QAnon is used as platform that opens up a space where they begin to ask questions, where they begin to doubt the competency of authority. They formulate doubts and complaints (\$) and look to the hegemonic master signifiers of scientists, politicians and the news (S₁),

⁴² Paul Verhaeghe, 'From impossibility to inability: Lacan's theory of the four discourses', *The Letter: Lacanian Perspectives on Psychoanalysis*, Vol. 3, (1995), p. 88.

⁴³ Mladen Dolar, 'Hegel as the Other Side of Psychoanalysis', in *Jacques Lacan and the Other Side of Psychoanalysis: Reflections on Seminar XVII*, ed. Justin Clemens and Russell Grigg, (Durham and London: Duke University Press, 2006), p. 143.

⁴⁴ Stijn Vanheule, 'Capitalist Discourse, Subjectivity and Lacanian Psychoanalysis', in *Frontiers in Psychology*, (2016), p. 3.

showing that they don't have the answers (S_2) that fully encapsulates and relieves the issue at hand (a). As the result of the objectivity of the knowledge created, they ignore the subjectivity of the subject. They want a signifier that explains everything, but as a result of *objet petit a*, this is impossible. Such members of QAnon – who lie in the discourse of the hysteric – therefore do not provide theories but instead only ask questions or formulate complaints ($\$-S_1$), doubting those who embody authority and experiencing dissatisfaction from each answer given ($a // S_2$). This results in the master realising their failure at mastery; the only way for the master to present knowledge for the hysteric is through speech, but the very moment he does, he reveals his division.⁴⁵ For example, the traumatic excess of COVID-19 and the deaths that followed led to the enforcement of masks. The hysteric QAnon member might complain about the fact that they have to wear a mask ($\$$), and when watching the news (S_1), they are given the science behind why they must wear one (S_2). However, even when the law is enforced, the virus continues to spread and the people around them are still dying. The hysteric notices the fact that the enforcement of masks did not stop the spread of COVID-19 (a), creating doubt of the competency of authority ($\$$) – highlighting the master's failure of mastery – for they are the Other who is supposed to know.

For those who treat the 'Q drops' less seriously may do so as a form of hysterical play, raising questions and complaints about the public Masters (scientists, politicians, the news) to show their incompleteness and uncertainty but never investing – with certainty – into the idea that there is indeed a secret Master (the 'deep state') working behind the scenes. Cynical distance towards official institutions is displayed, realising that authority's completeness is nothing but an illusion. The 'Q drops' are bound to *jouissance* as they force the subject to notice their lack, where they begin to formulate questions and complaints towards the social institutions in their quest for the truth, while at the same time allowing the listeners and readers

⁴⁵ Verhaeghe, *Does the Woman Exist? From Freud's Hysteric to Lacan's Feminine*, op. cit., p. 111.

of their own content to think, allowing them to try find out the truth themselves. In one sense, it can thus be said that the ‘Q drops’ allow QAnon to become the ultimate hysteric discourse, for one hysterical subject causes an avalanche of other hysterical subjects, all stemming from the ability to spread their doubts online.

The Demise of Symbolic Efficiency

With the split subject being in the position of agent, one by one the master signifiers that once were used to bring certainty start to crumble. There once were universal codes of what it meant to be ‘Good’, a ‘Nation’ or what was deemed as ‘Justice’ and ‘Freedom’ that the population followed, but now these words are treated with suspicion.⁴⁶ Terms like these were used only for the purpose of power: the master wanted power over the slave, doing so for control and in their own self-interest. All master signifiers are overshadowed with doubt – power and meaning of the societal institutions are called into question - and this is especially the case when there are times of crises, instability and large-scale traumatic experiences such as COVID-19. This is neatly encapsulated in what Žižek defines as “the demise of symbolic efficiency”; the demise of a functioning symbolic big Other.⁴⁷ The big Other is the third-party mediator between one agent to another; it is the “virtual symbolic order, the network that structures reality for us”; a communal network of social institutions, customs and laws.⁴⁸ As mentioned earlier, we now live in a society characterised by the existence of a plurality of competing narratives, where it is up to the individual themselves to devise meaning and identity. In addition to this, the internet has endowed us with the ability to access all these varying accounts with one quick search,

⁴⁶ Levi R. Bryant, ‘Žižek’s New Universe of Discourse: Politics and the Discourse of the Capitalist’, *International Journal of Žižek Studies*, vol. 2, no. 4, (2016), p. 22.

⁴⁷ Žižek, *The Ticklish Subject*, op. cit., p. 327.

⁴⁸ Slavoj Žižek, ‘The Matrix, or, the Two Sides of Perversion’, in *The International Handbook of Virtual Learning Environments*, eds. Joel Weiss, Jason Nolan, Jeremy Hunsinger and Peter Trifonas, (2006), p. 1552.

finding this multiplicity in an instant. Here lies the paradox of postmodernity: such freedom is felt as a burden, manifesting itself in a desire for discipline.⁴⁹

It therefore becomes apparent that we live in an Internet era characterised by reflexivity; an age predicated by a growing popularisation of the hermeneutics of suspicion.⁵⁰ A doctor tells the patient the reason behind why they are in pain and are thus given a prescription as means to heal their ailment. They might not believe the words of the doctor at first, leading to the patient searching on the internet, checking website after website to find out whether what the doctor said is true. This might lead them into seeking alternative medicine just in case, making sure that the pain does indeed stop. The big Other is that which tells us to take the word of the doctor, to trust his expert opinion. According to Žižek, symbolic efficiency “thus concerns the point at which, when the Other of the symbolic institution confronts me with a choice of ‘Whom do you believe, my word or your eyes?’, I choose the Other’s word without hesitation, dismissing the factual testimony of my eyes.”⁵¹ The discourse of the master uses master signifiers (S_1) as a means to achieve order within the galaxy of floating signifiers (S_2), creating the illusion that there is a stable and established meaning, that they are not castrated, and so are complete and in control.⁵² Therefore, we go with the master’s word even if we think otherwise. However, with the demise of symbolic efficiency, we are left only with our eyes. The symbolic father function is now viewed with suspicion; the big Other that provided us with a guaranteeing and answer-providing role is no longer convincing. We realise the big Other is a fiction – that it always has been – and we take it upon ourselves to find certainty and discipline through other means.

⁴⁹ Slavoj Žižek, *The Indivisible Remainder: An Essay on Schelling and Related Matters*, (London and New York: Verso, 1996), p. 25.

⁵⁰ Andrejevic, *Infoglut: How Too Much Information Is Changing the Way We Think and Know*, op. cit., p. 216.

⁵¹ Žižek, *The Ticklish Subject*, op. cit., p. 327.

⁵² Bryant, ‘Žižek’s New Universe of Discourse: Politics and the Discourse of the Capitalist’, op. cit., p. 22.

We can see this when QAnon doubt the credibility of news sources, calling them ‘fake news’, or when they adopt anti-science stances, showing doubt to such things like the effectiveness of COVID-19 vaccinations.⁵³ Therefore, in our ‘post-truth’ era, that which previously provided us with truth and meaning has fallen from grace. We lose trust in the previous masters of science, religion, politics and the news, leaving us to dwell upon the non-existence of the big Other. According to Žižek, this demise of symbolic efficiency and the boundless freedom produced causes the hysterical subject to try fill the traumatic experience of this void, and so may jump from one ‘little other’ to the next. They put their faith in these numerous ‘little others’ that promise to supply a sense of certainty in this uncertain world; the hysterical subject turns towards spiritual gurus and self-help youtubers in their search for a new master.⁵⁴ However, another response to such a demise is that the subject may try create a ‘short circuit’ between the imaginary register and the real, in effect bypassing the symbolic representations all together. This is exactly what Žižek – following Lacan – defines as paranoia: “the belief in the Big Other that exists in the Real.”⁵⁵

The Paranoid Construction of the ‘Deep State’

The majority of QAnon members are Republican and so were thrilled to hear the news that Trump had become the 45th president of the United States. However, him being placed in this position of power did not solve the traumatic excess of society (COVID-19, violence, lack of financial opportunities, instability, etc.). The non-existence of the Big Other – the demise of symbolic efficiency – made it difficult to make sense of such excesses, and so particular agents

⁵³ Tim Dickinson, ‘How the Anti-Vaxxers Got Red-Pilled’, *Rolling Stone*, (February 2021), <https://www.rollingstone.com/culture/culture-features/qanon-anti-vax-covid-vaccine-conspiracy-theory-1125197/>.

⁵⁴ Tony Myers, *Slavoj Žižek*, (London and New York: Routledge, 2003), p. 55.

⁵⁵ Žižek, *The Ticklish Subject*, op. cit., p. 362.

were compelled to fill these holes through different means. The imposed framework set about by the big Other is no longer convincing, so the subjects thus turn to conspiracy theory best exemplified in QAnon discourse as means to fill the holes, gaps and abrasions found within the big Other. They try fill these holes in an attempt to make the Other exist. The crumbling of symbolic efficiency thus pushes the subject into paranoia, where the big Other is not a symbolic fiction, holding the belief that it actually exists in the Real. Žižek explains that:

Two features characterize today's ideological stance – cynical distance and full reliance on paranoid fantasy – are strictly co-dependent: the typical subject today is the one who, while displaying cynical distrust of any public ideology, indulges without restraint in paranoid fantasies about the conspiracies, threats, and excessive forms of enjoyment of the Other.⁵⁶

Thus, the postmodern subject exhibits a cynical distancing towards the order of symbolic fictions (the big Other), distancing themselves from the hegemonic master and university discourses, from the official institutions that rule over us and provide us with knowledge. Not only that, an oversaturation in paranoid fantasies about the Other is also exhibited, and for the postmodern subject today, it is not at all uncommon to create the belief that there is a big Other that exists in the Real, an 'Other of the Other' who is really in control of not only us, but the world as we know it.⁵⁷ In such a delusion, the symbolic order is cut out completely. This belief of 'Other of the Other' that works from the shadows, existing as a "meta-guarantee of the consistency of the big Other",⁵⁸ is brought about by the yin and yang of cynical distancing of hegemonic institutions and paranoid fantasies of the Other – there is no need to invest yourself into the public ideology if the 'deep state' is the one pulling the strings. QAnon's belief in this cabal of Satanic, paedophilic elites is the perfect example of

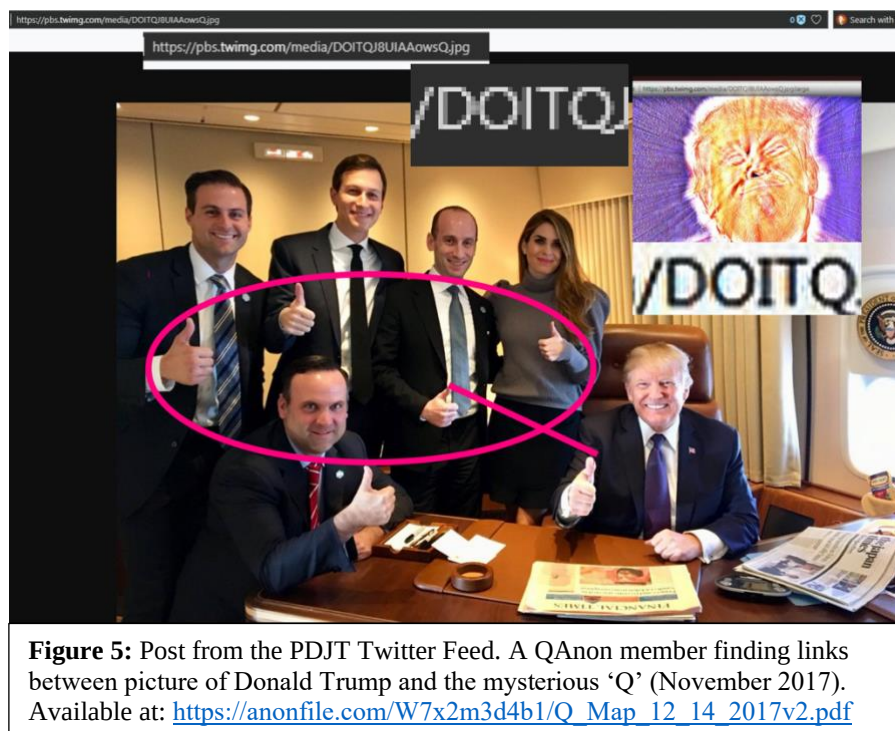
⁵⁶ Ibid.

⁵⁷ Ibid.

⁵⁸ Ibid.

such a meta-guarantee. This makes it evident that QAnon and the paranoid construction of a ‘deep state’s a condition of postmodernity, put into overdrive by our contemporary online information environment, forced into existence by the incessant need to escape the freedom that contemporary society encumbers you with.

Therefore, QAnon should not be reduced down to just modern mass hysteria, and this is due to the fact that the discourse of the hysteric relies on the ‘big Other’ of the symbolic order, it relies on a ‘normal’ perception of the social reality that we all share.⁵⁹ The psychotic – the paranoid subject – stands outside the four discourses of the neurotic, outside of ‘normal’ social relationships.⁶⁰ Consequently, the overindulgence in paranoic fantasies and cynical distrust of official institutions that is caused by the disintegration of the big Other should not be treated as ‘illness’ in the Freudian sense, for it is used as a means to heal themselves; it is a cure to the “breakdown of the symbolic universe”⁶¹ that has come about due to the demise of symbolic efficiency.



⁵⁹ Žižek, ‘The Matrix, or, the Two Sides of Perversion’, op., cit. p. 1555.

⁶⁰ Verhaeghe, ‘The Tactics of the Master: Paranoia versus Hysteria’, op. cit., p. 2.

⁶¹ Slavoj Žižek, *Looking Awry: An Introduction to Jacques Lacan through Popular Culture*, (Cambridge, Massachusetts and London: MIT Press, 1991), p. 19.

Through Barthes, the ‘Q’ posts were shown to exist as a galaxy of floating signifiers, where it is up to the reader to create meaning. The posts themselves do not contradict each individual’s paranoid fantasy, whatever it may be, for they can fit the post into their own worldview easily; they can pick the meaning of every post and believe it with certainty – this is a key aspect of paranoia. Even though the main premise is that there is a ‘deep state’ of paedophilic Satanists running the world from the shadows, there are differing opinions between the members concerning which conspiracy theories fit into ‘The Great Awakening’.⁶² The members only pick out what they want to pick out from the posts, creating what can be described as a closed circuit of *jouissance*, and what this means will be discussed later. It was also made evident that such posts are highly intertextual with other texts, and this can be seen in Figure 5. A QAnon member found this picture of Donald Trump where each of the individual’s thumbs were lined up, taking the form of the letter ‘Q’. Moreover, the link itself consisted of the phrase ‘DO IT Q’, denoting the fact that Trump is on the side of the ‘Patriots’, the QAnon members. Even though this is only a correlation, the QAnon member interpreted the text and took signification out of it, finding paranoid certainty through means of their own.

As suggested by Verhaeghe, the paranoid subject believes that they are not divided, that no lack in themselves exists. While the hysterical subject displays constant doubt, the paranoid QAnon member knows for certain and “transforms this knowledge into a system...in such a way that the accent shifts from desire to *jouissance*.”⁶³ Paranoia consists of the belief that the big Other exists in the Real, and the Real is the order of *jouissance*, hence the shift. Therefore, the fault or lack is always placed on the Other, and as mentioned prior, the subject may experience paranoid fantasies about the Other’s excessive forms of *jouissance*. We assume such enjoyment exists and thus lack it, and this absence of *jouissance* causes us to generally

⁶² Comedy Central, *Sitting Down with QAnon Conspiracy Theorists – The Jim Jeffries Show*, online video recording, YouTube, (August 2018), <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=VGrfN3v5JL8>.

⁶³ Verhaeghe, ‘The Tactics of the Master: Paranoia versus Hysteria’, op. cit.

ascribe it to the Other. We hold the belief that the Other is experiencing a level of enjoyment far beyond our own; the Other is believed to be in possession of the *jouissance* that we wish we had.⁶⁴ We believe full enjoyment is possible but all we are able to grasp are little scraps of it every once in a while. This type of boundless *jouissance* is fictitious, for it is the use of fantasy that keeps the belief in the unrestrained *jouissance* of the Other going. Put another way, it is more that the Other is the obstacle to our enjoyment that creates the illusion that full enjoyment is attainable, and this is done in a similar fashion to how Law creates desire.⁶⁵

For the majority of QAnon, they are politically right-wing, thus holding the belief that the Other (the ‘Deep State’, Jews, Democrats, Communists etc.) are enjoying themselves fully. However, the same could be said for the other side of the political spectrum as well. Leftists believe that QAnon are enjoying themselves fully; they see the Other (Republicans, Trump, QAnon, right-wing media) as having access to full *jouissance*. Therefore, both sides of the political spectrum develop this paranoid fantasy that the Other is experiencing *jouissance* illegitimately, and so believe that if they overthrow the Other, they will be able experience enjoyment fully for they are the culprits that have stolen their *jouissance*. QAnon was created on the internet, but the group has rippled into real-world controversies. The storming of the Capitol after President Joe Biden was elected involved the likes of many QAnon members,⁶⁶ thus showing the effects of the paranoid belief in the excessive *jouissance* of the other.

What was also mentioned earlier was the way ‘Q drops’ themselves are bound to *jouissance*. They make the reader notice their lack, causing them to hysterically question the hegemonic master signifiers at play. Castrilli6n makes an interesting point however, suggesting that the nature of digitalised social media itself allows for closed circuits of *jouissance/excess*

⁶⁴ Homer, op. cit., p. 90.

⁶⁵ Todd McGowan, *Enjoying What We Don’t Have: The Political Project of Psychoanalysis*, (Lincoln and London: University of Nebraska, 2013), p. 176.

⁶⁶ Gino Spocchia, ‘What role did QAnon play in the Capitol riot?’, *Independent*, (January 2021), <https://theconversation.com/qanon-and-the-storm-of-the-u-s-capitol-the-offline-effect-of-online-conspiracy-theories-152815>.

that cut out the need for a symbolic Big Other.⁶⁷ The Web and digitalised social media technologies are the perfect platform for paranoia as means to fill these gaps in the big Other, being used in a similar fashion to a drug addiction. It was previously suggested that *jouissance* is linked to the ‘death-drive’ – a sensation that goes beyond the pleasure principle – and a drug addiction is the perfect example of how *jouissance* functions.⁶⁸ The drug addict searches for *jouissance* and does so by pushing the sensation experienced by the drug further, getting closer and closer to the point of death.

The same can be said in relation to the constant usage of smart phones: we push the sensation of using them further and further, to the point where we are virtually scrolling through social media posts at every waking moment of the day. We can “switch the channel, scroll, or surf the internet until we find something that we really want to hear”, where we notice that there is “unmediated, uninterrupted, and seamless *jouissance* to be had” without the need of a third-party mediator: the symbolic big Other.⁶⁹ This type of engagement can be seen with the QAnon community. Prior to these online social media websites shutting down any ‘Q’ related content,⁷⁰ users used them to exploit these closed circuits of *jouissance*. In an age of ‘post-truth’ – the demise of symbolic efficiency – the words of others who opposed such talk could be easily dismissed if they got in the way of the constant flow of *jouissance*. In addition to this, the ‘Q drops’ are done in a fashion that is very much open to interpretation, where they send out an array of signifiers for conspiracy theorists to latch on to and create meaning. Therefore, every post feels like ‘Q’ is ‘lifting the veil’, that the members are about to be shown the real truth of things, and such a technique is used to catalyse these closed circuits of *jouissance*. The

⁶⁷ Fernando Castrillón, ‘No Leaders/No Masses: Virtuality and Contemporary Group Life in the Shadow of Freud’, *European Journal of Psychoanalysis*, (April 2021), <https://www.journal-psychoanalysis.eu/no-leaders-no-masses-virtuality-and-contemporary-group-life-in-the-shadow-of-freud/>.

⁶⁸ Bailey, op. cit., p. 228.

⁶⁹ Castrillón, op. cit.

⁷⁰ Shayan Sardarizadeh, ‘Twitter Suspends 70,000 accounts linked to QAnon’, *BBC*, (January 2021), <https://www.bbc.co.uk/news/technology-55638558>.

prospect of being shown the real truth hidden within these posts functions as a kind of absence that the QAnon member can fill in themselves, thus sustaining the circuit, keeping it electrified.⁷¹

Conclusion

After a close inspection of the functioning of QAnon, it comes as no surprise that there is much to say from a psychoanalytical perspective. Firstly, I aimed to convey how our current online information environment has endowed us with a condition associated with postmodernity: the ability to choose between an excess of competing accounts, all compacted online and found within an instant. Consequently, this crisis of representation is linked to what Žižek defines as the “demise of symbolic efficiency”, the disintegration of a functioning big Other. Through Barthes, it was shown that the implications of the “death of the author” were encapsulated within these ‘Q drops’, showing that it was completely up to the reader to create meaning from the posts. Moreover, establishing the posts as a Text makes it evident that they are bound to *jouissance*, creating a “state of loss” in the reader, forcing the QAnon members to hysterically question the assumptions they have on the world. This kind of questioning is found within Lacan’s discourse of the hysteric, where constant questioning and complaints directed towards both the master and knowledge reveals that the hysteric cannot be imprisoned in their symbolic network. This in turn discloses the master’s lack; the master signifiers at play begin to crumble one by one as the master’s authority is jeopardised. Accordingly, I portrayed how some members of QAnon reside in this discourse, presenting the manner in which they question and complain about ‘credible’ news sources and scientific studies. Once again, this aligns itself

⁷¹ Castrillón, *ibid.*

with the disintegration of symbolic efficiency; the discourse of the hysteric reveals the lack in the Other, calling the master signifiers into question.

Through the use of Žižek and his interpretation of Lacan, it becomes apparent that reality itself is becoming paranoid. With the collapse of the master signifiers that provided us with an imposed framework, the everyday postmodern subject is now characterised by paranoia: cynical distrust towards official institutions and an infatuation with paranoid fantasies of the growing threat of the Other (as a result of displacing their own lack onto the Other) are very noticeable traits of the QAnon worldview. It becomes apparent that QAnon creates this paranoid fantasy of an Other that exists in the Real, an ‘Other of the Other’ – the ‘deep state’ of Satanic paedophiles - who are the ones *really* pulling the strings of the failing authority, in order to escape the unbearable freedom that the absence of the big Other burdens us with. On that account, it was shown that the paranoid construction of the ‘deep state’ is not the illness itself, for it is an attempt to cure “the breakdown of the symbolic universe”.

From a Lacanian psychoanalytic perspective, the expansion of conspiracy theories seen in QAnon should thus be deemed as a symptom of the impotence of our societal system rather than a growing threat to it. In a similar manner to how alternative medicine shows the declining power of science, conspiracy theories highlight the declining power of our social order.⁷² We are beginning to see the conspiracy theory mindset witnessed in QAnon expand rapidly all across the globe.⁷³ Is this a sign of the deterioration of the global social order, a condition of postmodernity, globalisation and our current online information environment? We are endowed with the ability to pick and choose between a multiplicity of competing narratives, to decide upon our own meaning, to pick out our own imaginary identity. Through Žižek, it

⁷² Nebojša Blanuša and Todor Hristov, ‘Psychoanalysis, Critical Theory and Conspiracy Theory’, in *Routledge Handbook of Conspiracy Theories*, eds. Michael Butter and Peter Knight, (London and New York: Routledge, 2020), p. 78.

⁷³ Chris Mills Rodrigo, ‘QAnon spreads across the globe, shadowing COVID-19’, *The Hill*, (September 2020), <https://thehill.com/policy/technology/516102-qanon-spreads-across-globe-shadowing-covid-19>.

becomes apparent that the burden of this freedom provided by the demise of symbolic efficiency comes at a cost: a desire for order, discipline and certainty.

Furthermore, I attempted to dig deeper into the repercussions of QAnon's paranoid fantasies of the excessive *jouissance* of the Other ('Deep state', Democrats, Jews etc.) – that they are enjoying illegitimately - which leads to the incessant need to overthrow the Other as means to gain 'full' *jouissance*. Even though QAnon was born on the internet, this delusion and need to overthrow the Other in order to enjoy ourselves fully has led to real-world repercussions. The storming of the Capitol had an overabundance of QAnon members involved, seeking to take down the 'deep state'. What was also mentioned was how *jouissance* is linked to the 'death-drive' and so possesses an essentially masochistic structure - deriving pleasure in pain - and this masochism performs as the paradigmatic structure of our subjectivity.⁷⁴ Not only are the 'Q drops' bound to *jouissance*, the nature of digitalised social media sites are the perfect platforms for delusion, providing the members with a closed circuit of excess that 'short circuits' the need for symbolic representations completely. Thus, Todd McGowan's *Enjoying What We Don't Have* raises the question: is there a way to experience such lack and still be able to acquire adequate satisfaction from it without turning into masochists? Here lies the real dilemma.

⁷⁴ McGowan, *Enjoying What We Don't Have: The Political Project of Psychoanalysis*, p. 14.

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